

Episode 1: What are Colour Design and Colour Direction?

Nice to meet you. My name is **Tsujita Kunio** (辻田邦夫). I work in **colour design** and **colour direction**.

This time, I've been given the opportunity to write various things for **Anime Style**, and I hope you'll take care of me.

Articles and series about people involved in animation tend to focus on direction, scriptwriting, animation, and art backgrounds. The work of **colour direction** and **finishing** rarely gets featured. So here, I thought I'd write about finishing and **colour design/colour direction**... Though I still have no idea which direction this will go (laughs).

Well then.

In my animation work, I do **[finishing]**, mainly **colour design** and **colour direction**. Colour design? Colour direction? It's quite hard to understand, isn't it? This time, let me start with a general explanation of this work.

In the animation screen production process, after progressing through:

>**[storyboard]** → **[layout]** → **[key animation]** → **[in-between animation]**, the drawings are passed to **[finishing]**.

Here, the completed line drawings are coloured and materials are prepared for filming. But when told "paint it!", you can't know what colours to paint those drawings with. That's where the job of **[colour direction]** becomes necessary.

[Colour direction] checks the content of all cuts (key animation and in-between animation) for that story and adds specifications. For example, "this character uses this

colour model" or "this rock's colour is number XX from the colour chart" - adding simple, easy-to-understand "specifications" one by one. And for this, you need the basic colour models and rules as a foundation. Creating that is what **[colour design]** does.

The work of **[colour design]** is "creating and deciding the basic colours for characters" and "creating and deciding the colour direction for that work." You colour the character line drawings drawn by the character designer, but you construct the image through discussions and meetings with the director (direction), character designer, art director, and producers, then translate it into actual colours. When there's an original manga or similar source, you first reference the colours in that original work.

Based on the character colours decided this way, you create the colour worldview for that entire work. For this, coordination with **[art]** becomes important. "How dark should night scenes be?" "Is the western sun in evening scenes strong or weak?" - decisions are made while placing them on art boards (background paintings).

Then you meet with **[colour direction]** and request actual colour instructions. The teamwork between **[colour design]** and **[colour direction]** is important. While **[colour design]** makes judgements about the entire work, **[colour direction]** looks at individual actual drawings (key animation and in-between animation).

After having the colours specified this way, **[painting]** paints them, and then **[inspection]** checks whether the painted results are correct. This is roughly the **[finishing]** process. Then those OK cels are passed to **[photography]** for filming.

Well, I've explained it simply, but from next time I'll go into more depth.

PROFILE

Tsujita Kunio (辻田邦夫)

Born April 19, 1963. Active as colour designer and colour director. Representative works include the *Saint Seiya* (聖闘士星矢) series, theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* series, *Ojamajo Doremi* (おジャ魔女どれみ) series, *Gokinjo Monogatari* (ご近所物語), *Hana Yori Dango* (花より男子), etc. His personal website is "kunion's cafe" (<http://www.kunion.com/>).

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